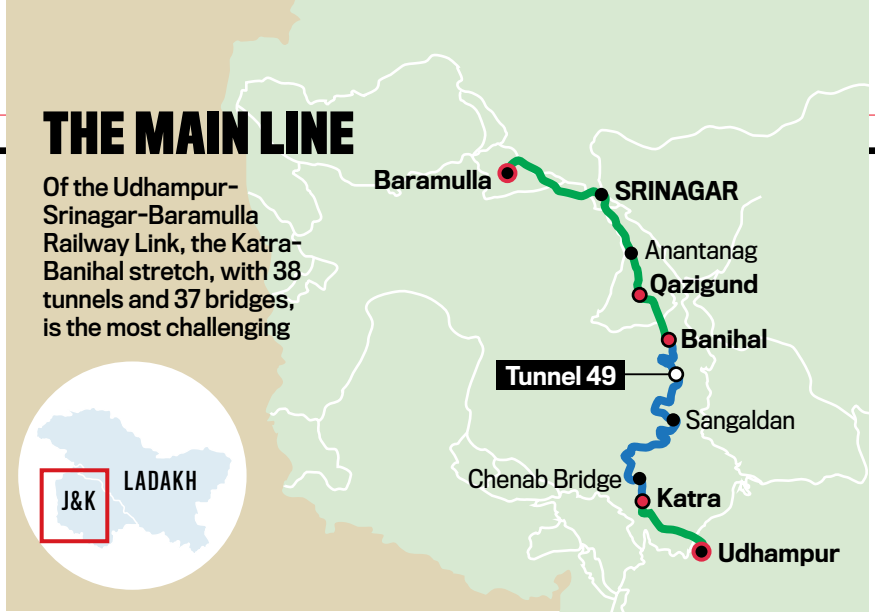
THE MAIN LINE

Of the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Railway Link, the Katra-Banihal stretch, with 38 tunnels and 37 bridges, is the most challenging



are high for the BJP—in ways that include but also go beyond the calculus of seats. As one of the two Union Territories the erstwhile state was bifurcated into, J&K (minus Ladakh) has six Lok Sabha constituencies: three each from Kashmir and Jammu. Assembly elections, too, have not been held since 2014; now, there's a Supreme Court deadline of September 2024. The showpiece projects Modi is showcasing have, therefore, not come at a bad time. Foremost among them is the 48.1 km Banihal-Khari-Sumber-Sangaldan railway line that he inaugurated, part of the Katra-Banihal section of the 272 km Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla (USBRL) railway link that will connect Kashmir with the rest of India.

This rail link boasts several standout features—among them, India's longest transport tunnel. Nestled in the Pir Panjals, the ambitious 12.7 km-long project, named T49, lies in the Ramban district between Sumber and Arpinchala stations in rugged mountainous terrain. Traffic promises to be bustling: the PM also flagged off electric trains on routes totalling 185.66 km on the Baramulla-Srinagar-Banihal-Sangaldan section—a significant step towards providing all-weather train connectivity to Kashmir.

"The Bharatiya Janata Party is fulfilling the dreams of people in J&K that were unmet for the past 70 years. Modi's guarantee is final...that everyone's dreams would be fulfilled," Modi said at the rally. News of bomb blasts, separatism and kidnappings, he added, were replaced by those of education, connectivity and development. In Jammu, Modi also inaugurated/laid the foundation of 209 development projects worth over Rs 32,000 crore. Prominent among them are an All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in Samba district, the IIM Jammu campus and a new terminal in Jammu airport. "People would forget Switzerland and come to J&K as infrastructure would get a big boost," he said on the occasion.

GUARANTEE FOR J&K

- On February 20, PM Narendra Modi addressed a rally in Jammu, signifying the start of the Lok Sabha poll campaign in J&K
- He guaranteed development for J&K, saying Gulf nations were keen on investing there
- PM Modi inaugurated two railway projects—the 48 km-long Banihal-Khari-Sumber-Sangaldan line and electric trains on the Baramulla-Sangal route
- One of the showpiece projects inaugurated by Modi is the T49 tunnel—at 12.7 km, it is India's longest railway tunnel
- Completion of the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla railway link (USBRL) connecting J&K with the rest of India is expected to drive development, bring investment
- PM Modi also inaugurated/announced projects in J&K worth over Rs 32,000 crore

Modi also deployed a trope he frequently uses against the Congress as he lit into the traditional Valley parties arrayed against the BJP. He said a "few families had clung on to power" in J&K since Independence without prioritising people's welfare. Without naming the National Conference or the People's Democratic Party, Modi said, "I am happy that J&K is now getting freedom from dynastic politics."

Eight electric trains will now run between Baramulla and Banihal and four of these have been extended to Jammu's Ramban sector, with Sangaldan as the new last or originating stop. In the coming months, this will further connect to one of the showpieces of the entire USBRL: the spectacular Chenab Bridge in Reasi district. This 1.3 km-long steel arch bridge over the emerald Chenab, coursing 359 metres below, is the world's highest railway bridge.

The T49 tunnel and the Chenab bridge are part of the rail link that promises a reliable connect to far-flung and poorly connected areas of J&K and is expected to spur economic growth and promote tourism. Declared a 'national project' in 2002, the USBRL is being constructed at an estimated cost of Rs 37,012 crore. Its execution has seen four phases: Udhampur-Katra (completed in July 2014), Banihal-Qazigund (completed in June 2013), Qazigund-Baramulla (in phases by 2009) and Katra-Banihal—the most formidable leg of the project. The 111 km Katra-Banihal corridor falls in Seismic Zone 4 territory and presents multiple construction challenges as it winds its way through mountains and an extensive riverine system that wraps around it with deep gorges. Over 97 km of the stretch comprises tunnels. It also has